

Ocean floor life

The deep ocean floor is a permanently dark, numbingly cold world. It is like a barren desert, with vast featureless plains covered with soft mud and ooze. Much of this is made up of the remains of dead plankton. This provides food for many animals that are specialized for collecting and eating it. There are also a lot of scavengers that feed on dead animals that have sunk to the ocean floor.

SOFT OOZE

The solid bedrock of the ocean floor is hard, dark basalt, but this is usually hidden by deep layers of soft sediment. Near the continents, a lot of this is sand and mud carried off the land by rivers or the wind. But in the open ocean, most of the sediment is the remains of tiny drifting organisms called plankton, which sink through the water and settle as soft ooze.

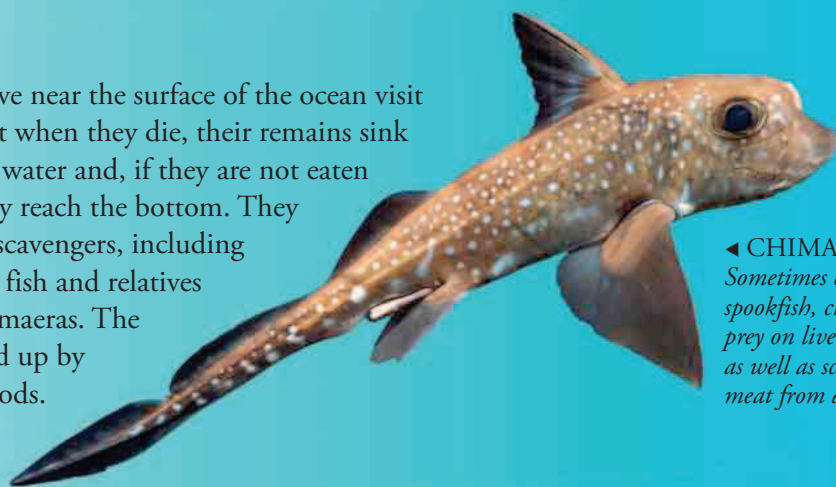


OOZE PROCESSORS

The organic ooze contains fragments of food that can be eaten by specialized animals called detritivores. They include deepwater sea cucumbers that suck up the ooze, and digest any edible material in the same way that earthworms process soil. These animals can be surprisingly colorful, although the red skin of this sea cucumber would look like the deepest black in the darkness of the ocean floor.

SCAVENGERS

Few animals that live near the surface of the ocean visit the ocean floor. But when they die, their remains sink slowly through the water and, if they are not eaten first, may eventually reach the bottom. They attract a variety of scavengers, including rat-tailed grenadier fish and relatives of sharks called chimaeras. The remains are finished up by shrimplike amphipods.



◀ CHIMAERA
Sometimes called
spookfish, chimaeras
prey on live animals
as well as scavenge
meat from dead ones.